

CLASS

Cosmological Linear Anisotropy Solving System



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These slides available at https://github.com/MarkMos/class_lecture

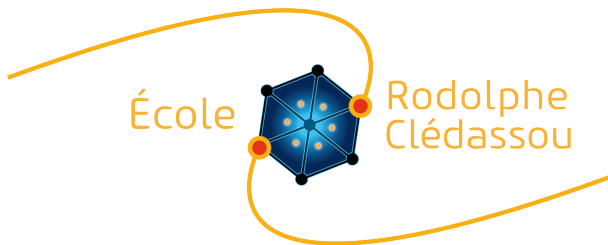
Visit <http://class-code.net/> for more info!

class in Pornichet

What to expect in these lectures:

- Basics: Why use **class**?
- Usage: Installation
- Usage: Python Interface
- Basics: Existing Species
- Basics: Module Overview
- Theory: What is **class** based upon?
- Coding: Implementing features

We will learn **how to use class** and **which models** can be run with it.



Fundamental layout of Einstein-Boltzmann solvers

Homogeneous background

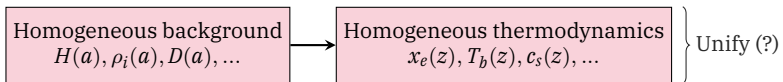
$H(a), \rho_i(a), D(a), \dots$



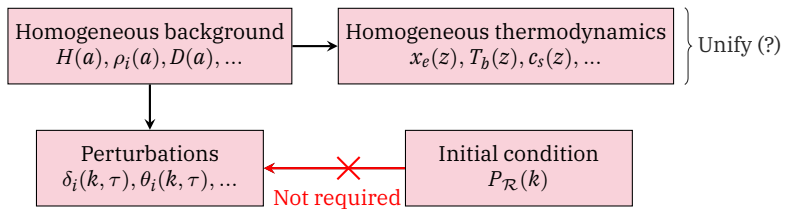
Homogeneous thermodynamics

$x_e(z), T_b(z), c_s(z), \dots$

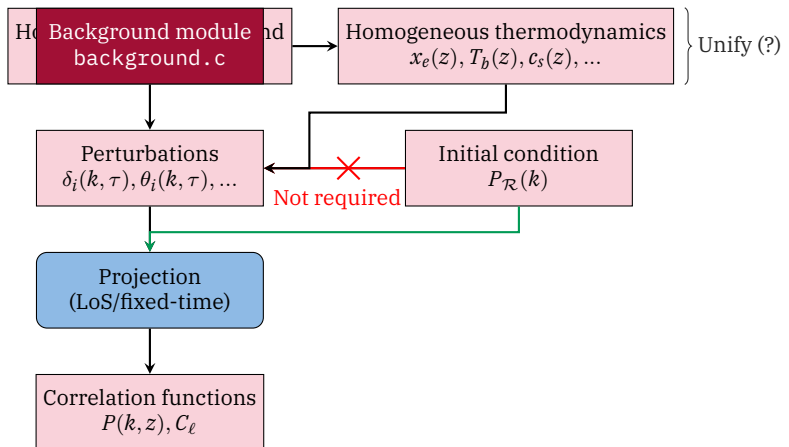
Fundamental layout of Einstein-Boltzmann solvers



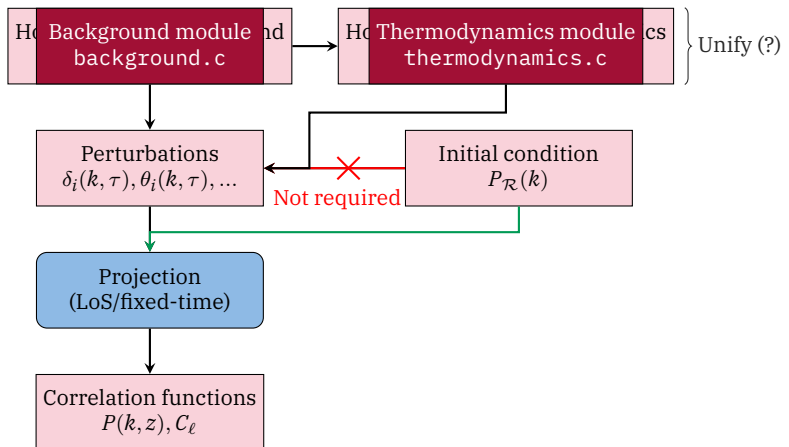
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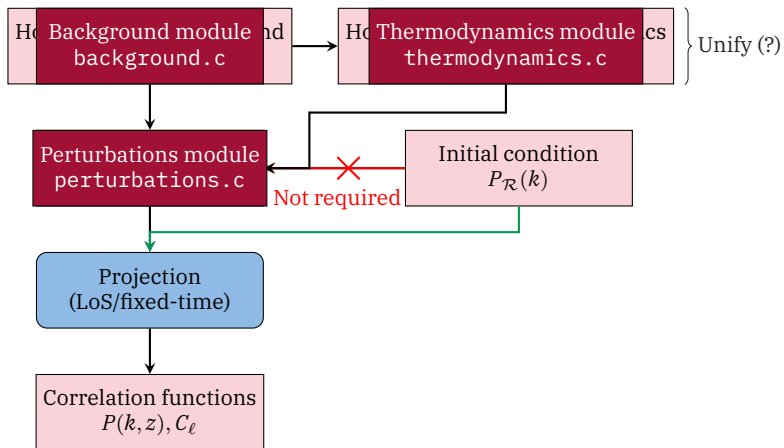
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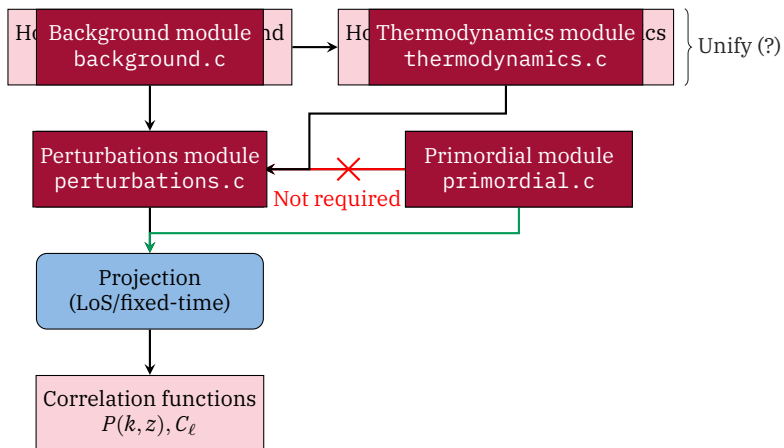
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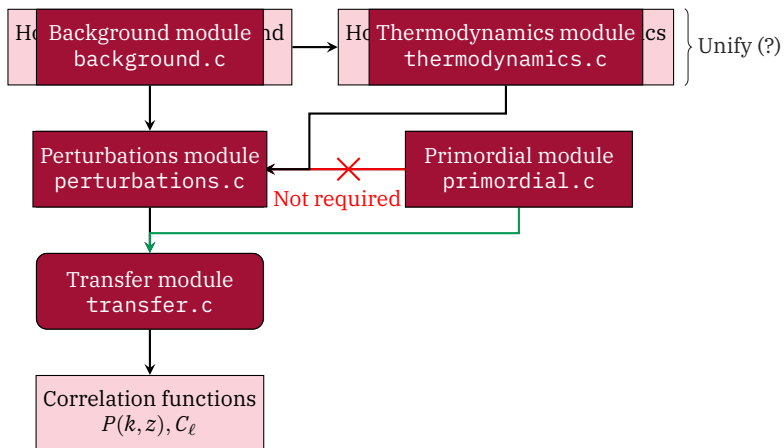
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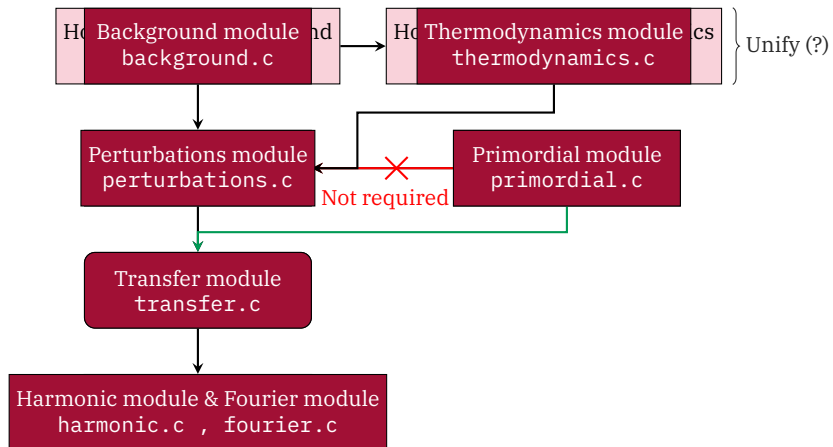
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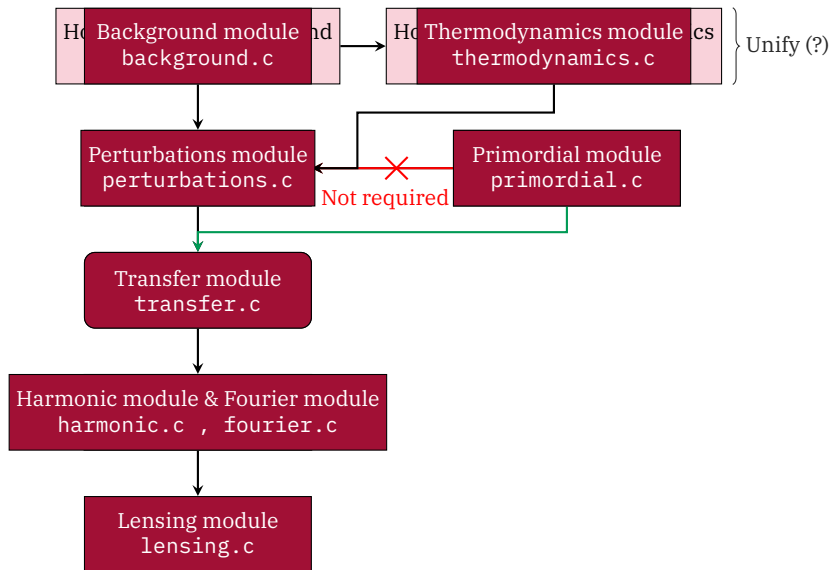
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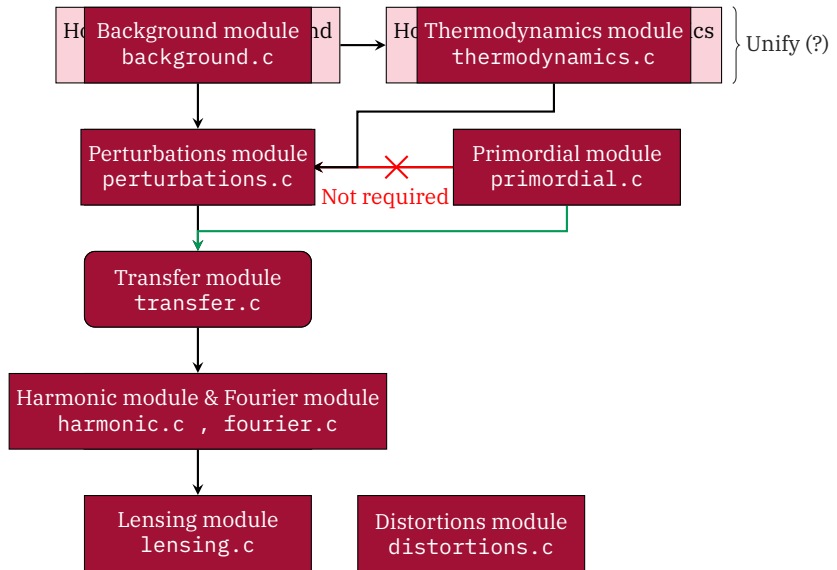
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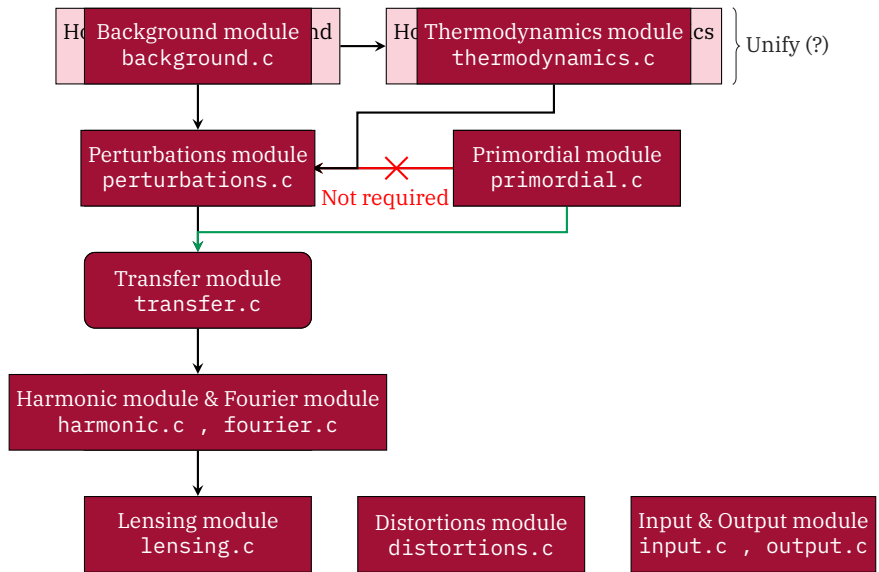
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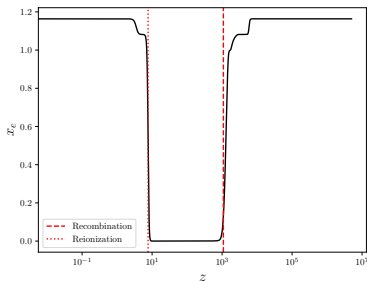


Let's make a journey through each module!

Essentials 3: Thermodynamics

Get all thermodynamics quantities as function of a time variable (**class** $\rightarrow$ redshift z) after integrating differential equations like recombination equations:

$$\frac{dx_e}{dz}, \frac{dT_b}{dz} = \text{excitation, ionization, heating, ...}$$



Then $x_e(z) \rightarrow \kappa'(z)$ (Thomson scattering rate)

$\rightarrow \kappa(z)$ (Optical depth)

$\rightarrow \exp(-\kappa(z))$ (factor for Integrated Sachs-Wolfe effect)

$\rightarrow g(z)$ (visibility function for Sachs-Wolfe effect)

$\rightarrow g'(z)$ (factor for Doppler effect)

The Thermodynamics Module

Simplest model of **recombination** is the **Saha equation**.

It is well known that a non-relativistic ($T \ll m$) species in thermal equilibrium obeys

$$n(\mu, T) \approx g e^{\mu/T} \left(\frac{mT}{2\pi} \right)^{3/2} e^{-m/T} \quad (1)$$

Thus we find using **complete thermal equilibrium** with $\mu_{\text{ionized}} + \mu_e = \mu_{\text{rec}}$ that

$$\frac{n_e n_{\text{ionized}}}{n_{\text{rec}}} \approx \left(\frac{m_e T}{2\pi} \right)^{3/2} e^{-E_{\text{bind}}/T} \times \underbrace{\left[e^{\mu_{\text{ionized}} + \mu_e - \mu_{\text{rec}}} \left(\frac{g_e g_{\text{ionized}}}{g_{\text{rec}}} \right) \left(\frac{m_{\text{ionized}}}{m_{\text{rec}}} \right)^{3/2} \right]}_{\approx 1}$$

This gives

$$\frac{x_e^2}{1 - x_e} \approx \left(\frac{1.1 \cdot 10^{-10}}{n_{\text{H},0}/T_{\text{cmb},0}^3} \right) \left(\frac{\text{eV}}{T} \right)^{3/2} \exp(39.9 - 13.6 \frac{\text{eV}}{T}) \quad (2)$$

and thus recombination at $T \approx \frac{13.6\text{eV}}{39.9} \approx 0.34\text{eV} \rightarrow z \approx 1400$.

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recombination is a non-equilibrium process

The Thermodynamics Module

The **effective multi-level atom** is the basis for recombination codes.

1s 2s 2p 3s 3p 3d ... ionized $\rightarrow$ 1s 2s 2p ionized

The Thermodynamics Module

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$1s\ 2s\ 2p\ 3s\ 3p\ 3d\ \dots$ ionized $\rightarrow 1s\ 2s\ 2p$ ionized

Reason: Intermediate transitions ($4p \rightarrow 3s$) or ($3s \rightarrow 2p$) are comparatively instant. Why? Direct transition $2s \rightarrow 1s$ is forbidden, and $2p \rightarrow 1s$ is immediately reversed by $1s \rightarrow 2p$. The medium is **optically thick** during recombination.

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Instead, focus on 2p $\rightarrow$ 1s with subsequent redshifting of photon to escape reabsorption (slow) or 2s $\rightarrow$ 1s with two-photon decay (slow).

Peeble's equation

$$\dot{x}_e \approx f_{\text{photo-ion}}(T)x_{\text{rec}} - f_{\text{rec}}(T)x_e x_{\text{ionized}} \quad (3)$$

Solved numerically, basis of **recfast**

The Thermodynamics Module

recfast only resolves $2s \approx 2p$

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Improvement: **HyRec** with EMLA resolves $2s, 2p$. Even more, can do $2s, 2p, 3s, \dots$ with *effective* rates.

Fullest code to date: **CosmoRec** does full numerical computation (iteratively).
Comparatively slow, but highest achievable accuracy

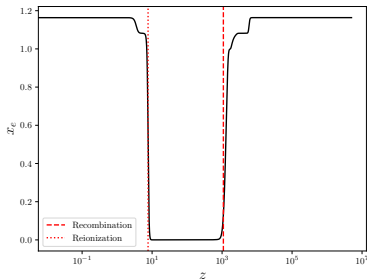
The Thermodynamics Module

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Further complication: Helium (higher elements don't contribute)



The Thermodynamics Module

User can choose to model approximate recombination and get $x_e(z)$, $T_b(z)$ from:

- **RECFAST** (Wong, Moss & Scott 2008)
- **HyRec-2** (Y. Ali-Haïmoud, N. Lee)
- Possibly soon? **CosmoRec** (J. Chluba)

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Recombination needs one more cosmological parameter: the **primordial Helium fraction** Y_{He} .

- Fix it ($Y_{\text{He}} = 0.25$)
- Get it from BBN ($Y_{\text{He}} = \text{BBN}$). **class** has interpolation table pre-pcomputed with a **BBN code** (**Parthenope**), for each given value of N_{eff} , ω_b (assumes $\mu_{\nu_e} = 0$, easy to generalize).
- BBN interpolation table located in separate directory (in `external/bbn/sBBN_2025.dat`, recently updated)

The Thermodynamics Module

For reionization:

- tanh with complicated argument (like **CAMB**)
- multi-tanh
- half tanh
- from file (either linear or tanh)

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Mini-shooting to find z_{reio} for given $\tau_{\text{reio}} = \kappa_{\text{reio}}$.

Optical depth $\kappa(z)$ = inverse number of expected interactions $\Rightarrow \kappa'(z) = an_H x_e \sigma_T$

The Thermodynamics Module

We also include

- Energy injection (increases ionization, heats T_b)
This can cause changes in scattering $\kappa(z)$ and thus be observable with CMB
- Time-dependent fundamental constants $\rightarrow$ Causes shift in recombination due to fundamental dependencies such as
$$E_{\text{binding}} = \frac{1}{2}\alpha^2 m_e = 13.6\text{eV} (137\alpha)^2 \left(\frac{m_e}{511\text{keV}}\right)$$
We remind ourselves $1 + z_{\text{rec}} = T_{\text{rec}}/T_{\text{cmb}} \approx \frac{E_{\text{binding}}}{12.57\text{meV}}$
- Computation of useful quantities $z_{\text{rec}}, z_{\text{drag}}, z_*, D_A(z_{\text{rec}}), r_s(z_{\text{drag}}), \dots$

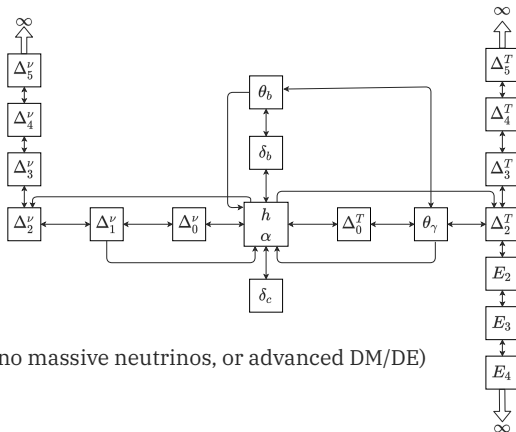
Thermodynamics exercise

Let's check this with an exercise!

Download the jupyter notebook [Exercise_thermodynamics_to_fill.ipynb](#) and follow the steps to plot the properties computed by the Thermodynamics module.

Essentials 4: Perturbations

- Find all perturbations ($\delta_X(\tau, k)$, $\phi(\tau, k)$, ...) by integrating ODEs for each independent wavenumber k , each mode (scalar/tensor), each initial condition (adiabatic/isocurvature)



Minimal set! (no massive neutrinos, or advanced DM/DE)

The Perturbations Module

- Find all perturbations ($\delta_X(\tau, k)$, $\phi(\tau, k)$, ...) by integrating ODEs for each independent wavenumber k , each mode (scalar/tensor), each initial condition (adiabatic/isocurvature):
 - Boltzmann
 - Continuity + Euler
 - linearized Einstein equations (one = ODE, others = constraint equations)

Linear perturbations $\Rightarrow$ perturbations normalized to initial condition
(**class** $\rightarrow$ curvature $\mathcal{R} = 1$ for scalar with adiabatic I.C.)

The Perturbations Module

Einstein Equations

$$k^2\phi + 3\mathcal{H}(\phi' + \mathcal{H}\psi) = -4\pi Ga^2\delta\rho \quad (4)$$

$$k^2(\phi' + \mathcal{H}\psi) = 4\pi Ga^2(\rho + P)\theta\phi'' + \mathcal{H} \quad (5)$$

$$(\psi' + \phi') + (2\mathcal{H}' + \mathcal{H}^2)\psi + \frac{1}{3}k^2(\phi - \psi) = 4\pi Ga^2\delta P \quad (6)$$

$$k^2(\phi - \psi) = 12\pi Ga^2(\rho + P)\sigma \quad (7)$$

and Boltzmann equations

$$\frac{dF_0^{(\gamma)}}{d\eta} + kF_1^{(\gamma)} = 4\phi' \quad (8)$$

$$\frac{dF_1^{(\gamma)}}{d\eta} - \frac{k}{3} [F_0^{(\gamma)} - 2F_2^{(\gamma)}] = \frac{4k}{3}\psi + \underbrace{\Gamma_{\gamma,b}}_{\text{from thermodynamics}} [F_1^{(b)} - F_1^{(\gamma)}] \quad (9)$$

$$\frac{dF_2^{(\gamma)}}{d\eta} - \frac{k}{5} [2F_1^{(\gamma)} - 3F_3^{(\gamma)}] = \underbrace{\Gamma_{\gamma,b}}_{\text{from thermodynamics}} [-F_2^{(\gamma)} + \Pi^{\text{pol}}/10] \quad (10)$$

$$\frac{dF_\ell^{(\gamma)}}{d\eta} - \frac{k}{2\ell+1} [\ell F_{\ell-1}^{(\gamma)} - (\ell+1)F_{\ell+1}^{(\gamma)}] = 0 \quad (\text{infinite hierarchy}) \quad (11)$$

The Perturbations Module

4 Einstein Equations (only one dynamical)

1 $\ell_{\max}^{(\gamma)}$ photon temperature hierarchy

1 $\ell_{\max}^{(\gamma)}$ photon polarization hierarchy (or 2 $\ell_{\max}^{(\gamma)}$)

2 baryon (density, velocity)

1/2 cdm equations (density?, velocity)

Either

a) 1 $\ell_{\max}^{(\text{dr})}$ massless neutrino hierarchy

b) 1 $\ell_{\max}^{(\text{dr})}$ massless neutrino hierarchy

+ $N_{\text{ncdm}} \cdot \ell_{\max}^{(\text{ncdm})} \cdot N_q$ massive neutrino hierarchies

= Too many equations for simple solvers!

(also tight coupling == stiff equations)

(also sparse system)

The Perturbations Module

ODE Solver (customized for Einstein-Boltzmann equations)

- Stiff system require implicit method like backward Euler or more advanced:
→ find $\mathbf{y}_{n+1}$ as a solution of $\mathbf{y}_{n+1} = \mathbf{y}_n + \mathbf{y}'(\mathbf{y}_{n+1})\delta t$
- Still fast: Newton method with Jacobian recycling
- Robustness requires δt to be adaptive time step
- Source function required at predefined t_i : on-the-fly interpolation
- System is sparse: some algebra gives big speed up (sparse LU decomposition)

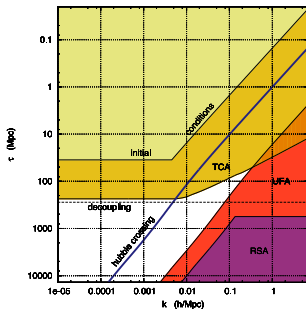
Everything gathered in ndf15 by T. Tram (CLASS II 2011).
TCA could even be removed!

The Perturbations Module

ODE approximations (papers : CLASS II & CLASS IV 2011)

Idea of these approximations: Reduce number of evolved equations.

- Tight Coupling Approximation for baryons and γ at 2nd order $\rightarrow$ Suppresses shear & higher moments whenever $k\tau_{b\gamma} \ll 1$
- Ultrarelativistic Fluid Approximation (for massless ν , also one for massive ones): truncated Boltzmann, 3 equations $\rightarrow$ Suppresses higher order moments whenever $k\tau \gg 1$
- Radiation Streaming Approximation (for photons and massless ν): test particles, 0 equations $\rightarrow$ Only follow oscillation-averaged evolution when $k\tau \gg \ell$ (+ for photons $k\tau_{b\gamma} \gg 1$)

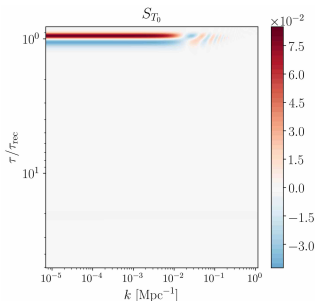


The Perturbations Module

Source functions

- Keep memory not of everything, but anything useful for final calculation of observables:
 - raw transfer function ($\delta_m(\tau, k) \rightarrow P_m(k, z)$)
 - non-trivial combinations (photon, baryon, metric, thermodynamical functions $\rightarrow$ CMB source functions $S_{T_i}(k, \tau)$)

All these are called *source functions* in **class**



The Perturbations Module

Photon hierarchies

Two approaches to polarization in Boltzmann hierarchy:

- Ma & Bertschinger 1994 (optimal):
 $(F_\ell, G_\ell) \rightarrow (S_T, S_P) \rightarrow (\Delta_\ell^T, \Delta_\ell^E, \Delta_\ell^B)$: $2\ell_{\max}$ equations, only flat!
- Hu & White 1997 (TAM):
 $(\Theta_\ell, E_\ell, B_\ell) \rightarrow (S_T, S_E, S_B) \rightarrow (\Delta_\ell^T, \Delta_\ell^E, \Delta_\ell^B)$: $3\ell_{\max}$ equations!

The Perturbations Module

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CMBFAST: first in flat space, second in curved space

The Perturbations Module

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CAMB: always second case

The Perturbations Module

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CMBFAST: first in flat space, second in curved space

CAMB: always second case

class: first case by default, thanks to new analytic results in curved space
(T. Tram & JL, JCAP 2013 [arXiv:1305.3261], approximation!)

User can select second case

Perturbations exercise

Let's check this with an exercise!

Download the jupyter notebook [Exercise_perturbations_to_fill.ipynb](#) and follow the steps to plot the properties computed by the Perturbations module.

Essentials 5: Primordial

Initial conditions for scalars (adiabatic, isocurvature) and tensors. Linear theory
 $\Leftrightarrow$ Gaussian independent Fourier modes $\Leftrightarrow$ only power spectrum required

- analytic: primordial power spectra as parametric functions (e.g. power-law)
- inflation mode: solve background+perturbation equation for single-field inflation and compute primordial scalar/tensor spectrum numerically

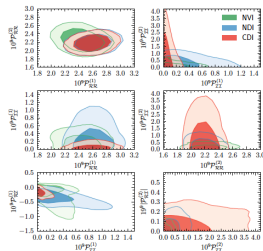


Fig. 22. Two dimensional distributions for power in isocurvature modes, using *Planck*+WP data.

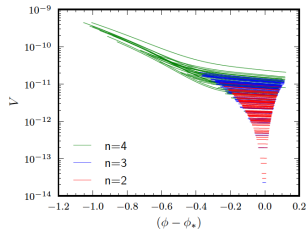


Fig. 14. Observable range of the best-fitting inflaton potentials, when $V(\phi)$ is Taylor expanded at the n th order around the pivot value ϕ_* , in natural units (where $\sqrt{8\pi}M_{\text{pl}} = 1$), assuming a flat prior on ϵ_V , η_V , ξ_V^2 , and ϖ_V^3 , and using *Planck*+WP data.

The Primordial module

Primordial spectra : modes

P_k_ini type =	modes =	ic =
analytic_Pk inflation_V inflation_H inflation_V_end	at least one: s,t s,t s,t s,t	at least one: ad,bi,cdi,nid,niv ad ad ad
external_Pk	at least one: s,t	ad

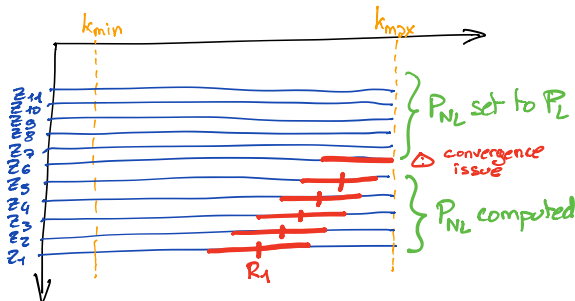
Essentials 6: Fourier

- Linear matter power spectrum $P_m(k, z) \rightarrow$ integrated quantities $\sigma(R, z), \sigma_8(z)$
- Linear baryon+CDM power spectrum $P_{cb}(k, z) \rightarrow$ integrated quantities $\sigma_{cb,8}(z)$
- Approximation for non-linear spectrum $P_m^{NL}(k, z)$ based on prescriptions like [Halofit](#), [HMcode](#)...
- Keep also non-linear correction factor $(R^{NL}(k, z))^2 = P_m^{NL}(k, z)/P_m(k, z)$ for e.g., CMB lensing, cosmic shear, number count C_ℓ 's

The Fourier Module

How to emulate non-linear evolution with a halo model?

Halofit or HMcode require non-linearity scale $R_{\text{NL}}(z)$ such that $\sigma(R_{\text{NL}}(z), z) = 1$.



To get $P^{\text{NL}}(k, z)$ at higher z one should increase k_{max} .

The Fourier Module

Halofit relies on simple similarity solution Ansatz:

$$\Delta_{1-\text{halo}}^2(k) = \underbrace{\frac{a_n y^{3f_2}}{(1 + b_n y^{f_2} + (f_3 c_n y)^{3-\gamma_n})}}_{\text{Original term, corrected with } f_2} \underbrace{\frac{1}{(1 + x_\mu y^{-1} + x_\nu y^{-2})(1 + 0.977 f_\nu)}}_{\text{Further corrections}}$$

with $y = k/k_{\text{nl}} = kR_{\text{NL}}(z)$.

Parameters calibrated to fit (early) simulations reasonably well.

$$\Delta_{\text{nl}}^2 \approx \Delta_{2-\text{halo}}^2 + \Delta_{1-\text{halo}}^2 \text{ with } \Delta_{2-\text{halo}}^2 \approx \frac{(1 + \Delta_{\text{lin}}^2)^\beta}{(1 + \alpha \Delta_{\text{lin}}^2)} \cdot \exp(-y/4 - y^2/8) \text{ with}$$

$$\Delta_{\text{lin}}^2 = P_{\text{lin}}(k, z) \frac{k^3}{2\pi^2}$$

Summary: Simple analytical fitting formula

The Fourier Module

HMcode has a more complicated halo model:

- $\Delta_{\text{nl}}^2 \approx \left(\left(\Delta_{2\text{-halo}}^2 \right)^\alpha + \left(\Delta_{1\text{-halo}}^2 \right)^\alpha \right)^{1/\alpha}$
- $P_{2\text{-halo}} = [P_{\text{lin}} + (f_{\text{dewiggle}} - 1.)P_{\text{BAO-wiggle}}] \times \{1 - f_{\text{damp}} \cdot (k/k_{\text{damp}})^{\alpha_{\text{damp}}} / [1 + (k/k_{\text{damp}})^{\alpha_{\text{damp}}}] \}$
- $P_{1\text{-halo}} = \int n(\nu k^\eta) g(\nu) dm$
- $\nu = \delta_c / \sigma(R(m))$
- $g(\nu) = A \cdot (1 + (q\nu^2)^{-p}) \exp(-q\nu^2/2)$ Sheth-Tormen HMF
- $n(x) = \text{NFW halo profile}$

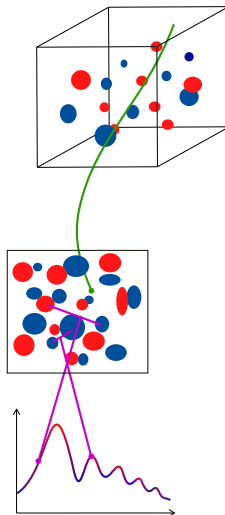
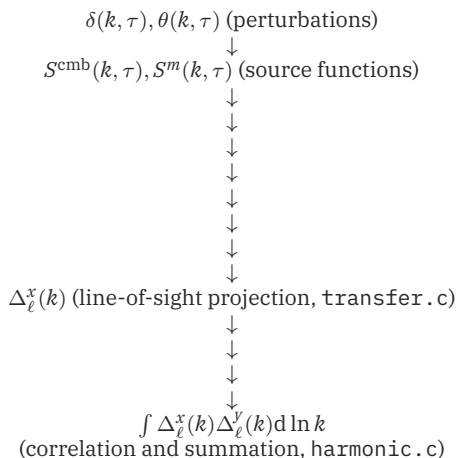
Summary: Physically motivated halo formula, reproduces well current simulations

Fourier exercise

Let's check this with an exercise!

Download the jupyter notebook [Exercise_fourier_to_fill.ipynb](#) and follow the steps to plot the properties computed by the Fourier module.

Essentials 7+8: Transfer & Harmonic



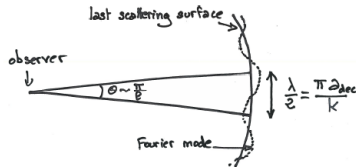
Transfer & Harmonic Modules

CMB spectrum depends on $\Delta_\ell^X(k) = \ell$ -th multipole of anisotropy of photon temperature and polarisation ($X \in \{T, E, B\}$) today ($\tau = \tau_0$).

Since **CMBFAST** (Seljak & Zaldarriaga 1996): use “line-of-sight integral”

$$\Delta_\ell^X(k) = \int_\epsilon^{\tau_0} d\tau S^X(\tau, k) j_\ell(k(\tau_0 - \tau))$$

$S(\tau, k)$ = source function from above. Role of Bessel: projection from Fourier to harmonic space ($\theta d_a(z_{\text{rec}}) = \frac{\lambda}{2}$ gives precisely $l = k(\tau_0 - \tau_{\text{rec}})$):



Curved space: spherical bessel functions $\rightarrow$ modified Bessel functions (hypergeometric)

Transfer & Harmonic Modules

$$\Delta_{\ell}^X(k) = \int_{\epsilon}^{\tau_0} d\tau S^X(\tau, k) j_l(k(\tau_0 - \tau))$$

applies not just to CMB $X \in \{T, E, B\}$ but also all LSS C_{ℓ} 's (one X per type of observable and redshift bin).

- CMB lensing + cosmic shear: $S(\tau, k)$ involves broad window function)
- number count (galaxy clustering): $S(\tau, k)$ modeled fully relativistically (RSD, Doppler, lensing, other GR effects)
- may include non-linear correction factors $R^{NL}(k, z)$

Transfer & Harmonic Modules

Well known

$$\Delta_\ell(k) = \int_\epsilon^{\tau_0} d\tau S_T(\tau, k) j_\ell(k(\tau_0 - \tau))$$

$$\text{with } S_T(\tau, k) \equiv \underbrace{g(\Theta_0 + \psi)}_{\text{SW}} + \underbrace{(g k^{-2} \theta_b)'}_{\text{Doppler}} + \underbrace{e^{-\kappa}(\phi' + \psi')}_{\text{ISW}} + \text{polarisation}$$

comes from integration by part of:

$$\begin{aligned} \Delta_l(k) = \int_{\tau_{\text{ini}}}^{\tau_0} d\tau \{ & S_T^0(\tau, k) j_l(k(\tau_0 - \tau)) \\ & + S_T^1(\tau, k) \frac{dj_l}{dx}(k(\tau_0 - \tau)) \\ & + S_T^2(\tau, k) \frac{1}{2} \left[3 \frac{d^2 j_l}{dx^2}(k(\tau_0 - \tau)) + j_l(k(\tau_0 - \tau)) \right] \} \end{aligned}$$

But $(S_T^1)'$, $(S_T^2)'$, $(S_T^2)''$ problematic! (Derivative of Einstein equation, massive neutrinos $\rightarrow$ finite differences...)

Transfer & Harmonic Modules

So we should rather stick to

$$\begin{aligned}\Delta_l(k) = \int_{\tau_{\text{ini}}}^{\tau_0} d\tau \big\{ & S_T^0(\tau, k) j_l(k(\tau_0 - \tau)) \\ & + S_T^1(\tau, k) \frac{dj_l}{dx}(k(\tau_0 - \tau)) \\ & + S_T^2(\tau, k) \frac{1}{2} \left[3 \frac{d^2 j_l}{dx^2}(k(\tau_0 - \tau)) + j_l(k(\tau_0 - \tau)) \right] \big\}\end{aligned}$$

CLASS v2.0 stores separately $S_T^0(\tau, k)$, $S_T^1(\tau, k)$, $S_T^2(\tau, k)$, and the transfer module will convolve them individually with respective bessel functions.

$$S_T^0 = g \left(\frac{\delta_g}{4} + \psi \right) + e^{-\kappa} (\phi' + \psi') \quad S_T^1 = g \frac{\theta_b}{k} \quad S_T^2 = \frac{g}{8} (G_0 + G_2 + F_2)$$

or

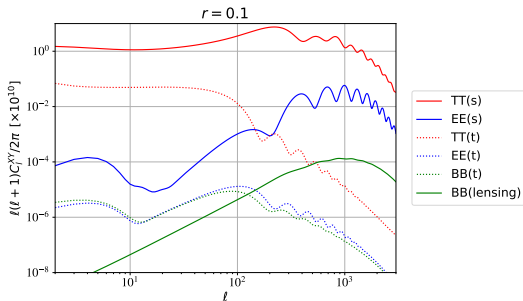
$$S_T^0 = g \left(\frac{\delta_g}{4} + \phi \right) + e^{-\kappa} 2\phi' + g'\theta_b + g\theta_b' \quad S_T^1 = e^{-\kappa} k(\psi - \phi) \quad S_T^2 = \frac{g}{8} (G_0 + G_2 + F_2)$$

Transfer & Harmonic Modules

Last step is (almost) trivial:

$$C_{\ell}^{XY} = \int \frac{dk}{k} \sum_{ij} \Delta_{\ell i}^X(k) \Delta_{\ell j}^Y(k) \mathcal{P}_{ij}(k)$$

with sum running over modes (scalar/tensor) and I.C. (adiabatic/isocurvature).



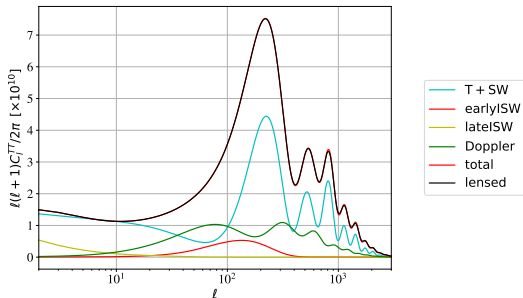
Harmonic exercise

Let's check this with an exercise!

Download the jupyter notebook [Exercise_harmonic_to_fill.ipynb](#) and follow the steps to plot the properties computed by the Harmonic module.

Essentials 9: Lensing

- metric fluctuations $(\phi, \psi) \rightarrow$ lensing potential source function $\rightarrow$ CMB lensing potential spectrum C_ℓ^{PP}
- several quadratic sums over $C_{\ell_1}^{XY} C_{\ell_2}^{PP} \rightarrow$ lensed CMB spectra $C_\ell^{TT, TE, EE, BB}$. Full-sky approach of Challinor & Lewis 2005.



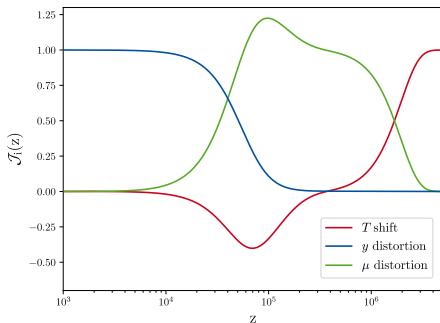
Essentials 10: Spectral Distortions

- Computations using CosmoTherm to derive thermalization Green's function
- Using Green's function to compute μ, y amplitudes

Simplified view:

$$a = \int \dot{Q} J_a(t) dt \quad (12)$$

with branching function $J_a(t)$.



Essentials 11: Output

Writes output files with correct headers and data.

If you are ever in doubt about `class` output units, check the headers of an output file.

Implementing new features

If you want to implement:

- a new species
- a new approximation scheme to simplify some equations in some regime
- a new mathematical description of an existing species (switching on more precise corrections, etc.)
- a new observable or output (new source function, new transfer function, new spectrum...)

the logic is always the same:

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- 4 duplicate these occurrences
- 5 change `fld` into `earde`
- 6 change some equations to describe the specific properties of your feature